

GREAT IDEAS GREAT MINDS

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Reservation needs to be **REVAMPED** if it is to continue serving the cause of social justice



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

Nothing, it appears, is calculated to agitate middle class Indians as much as the vexed question of reservations. The battle lines have been drawn firmly on more than one occasion, and every few years events call to mind the tumultuous street battles that broke out in 1990-91 when the V.P. Singh government declared its intention to implement the Mandal Commission's recommendation to increase quotas in government jobs and university seats by 27 to 49.5 per cent and thereby, as the Commission thought, reaffirm the declared intention of the

Constitution's framers to transform India into a modern republic where equality of opportunity would prevail for all citizens.

The debate has been in stark oppositional terms, between those who claim to stand for "merit" and those who claim allegiance to higher norms of "social justice". Opponents allege that quotas severely compromise standards of excellence, and that meritorious candidates are excluded in favour of less "qualified" applicants who can claim membership in some excluded group targeted for help—the Constitution's promise of equality of opportunity, in the name of which reservations are upheld,

Fired up: An anti-quota protest against Mandal Commission report in 1991